

- G** question formation
V figuring out meaning from context
P intonation: showing interest

Lesson plan

The topic and the grammar focus of this first lesson is questions. Even at this level, many Sts still have problems forming questions correctly. This lesson aims to review all aspects of question formation, including indirect questions, negative questions, and questions that end with a preposition. By the end of the lesson, Sts should be forming questions more accurately and more confidently, and we suggest that from then onwards you insist on questions always being formed correctly.

The lesson has two distinct halves. In the first half, Sts read two interviews from Q&A, a regular feature in *The Guardian* newspaper, with the gymnast Simone Biles and the actor Dan Stevens. They then focus on the grammar of question formation and this is followed by Pronunciation, which reviews how to use intonation in questions to show interest. In the second half, the topic is job interviews and Sts read an article about the kind of “extreme” questions that some companies now use. The vocabulary focus is on figuring out the meaning of new words in a text from context. This is followed by a listening where Sts hear four speakers talk about strange questions they have been asked in interviews. The lesson ends with Speaking, where Sts role-play extreme interviews and write a question of their own.

If you would like to begin the first lesson without the book, there are two photocopiable “first day” activities on p.161 and pp.190–191 (instructions p.183).

There is an Entry Test in the *Teacher Resource Center*, which you can give Sts before starting the course.

More materials

For teachers

Photocopyables

Grammar introduction p.161

question formation p.162

Communicative Tell me about it pp.190–191
(instructions p.183)

Ask me a question p.192
(instructions p.183)

Teacher Resource Center

Entry test

For students

Workbook 1A

Online Practice 1A

OPTIONAL LEAD-IN – THE QUOTE

Write the quote at the top of p.6 on the board and the name of the person who said it, or get Sts to open their books and read it.

You could point out / elicit that Oscar Wilde (1854–1900), a playwright and poet, is famous in particular for his novel *The Picture of Dorian Gray* and play *The Importance of Being Earnest*. Elicit / Explain what *indiscreet* means.

Get Sts to discuss what they think it means. Do they agree with the quote?

1 READING & SPEAKING understanding questions

- a** Focus on the photos and ask Sts if they know anything about the two people. Elicit as much information as you can. If they don't know them at all, tell Sts that they are both very well known, and that after reading about them, they may want to watch Simone's competitions and / or watch some of Dan's TV shows or movies.

Give Sts time to read about who they are.

Elicit answers to the two questions and tell Sts if you know them and what you think of them.

- b** Focus on the two interviews and ask Sts what the title Q&A means (= *Questions and Answers*).

Then give Sts time to read the interviews and complete the questions. Point out the **Glossary**. You may also want to elicit / explain *wallpaper* (= the background pattern or picture you choose to have on the screen of your phone, computer, etc.) and the expression *a guilty pleasure* (= sth you enjoy, but think you shouldn't) in Dan's questions.

Get Sts to compare with a partner, and then check answers. You may want to point out that although *Who* would also fit Dan's question 4, it would not be a natural question to ask someone in an interview, as it would presuppose that the answer was a person, whereas the answer could be anything, e.g., a neighbor's dog, worrying about something, etc.

EXTRA SUPPORT Before Sts read the interviews the first time, check whether you need to pre-teach any vocabulary.

Simone Biles

1 What 2 did 3 don't 4 was 5 who 6 would
7 When 8 How 9 Which

Dan Stevens

1 When 2 do 3 What 4 What 5 Who 6 would
7 How 8 does 9 Do

- c** Focus on questions 1–8 and go through them quickly, making sure Sts understand all the vocabulary. Highlight that the questions begin *Who do you think...?* not *Who...?* because the answers are implied rather than directly stated.

Now tell Sts to read the interviews again and to answer the questions with the celebrities' initials.

Get Sts to compare with a partner, and then check answers.

- 1 D – question 9
- 2 S – question 5
- 3 D – question 7
- 4 S – question 4
- 5 D – questions 1 and 8
- 6 D – questions 1, 2, 3, and 4
- 7 S – question 7
- 8 S – question 3

EXTRA CHALLENGE You could get Sts to close their books, and then call out some of the answers (or part of the answers) from the two Q&A questionnaires, to see if Sts can remember the questions, e.g.,

T *I go for walks in Griffith Park, in LA.*

Sts *How do you relax?*

T *Oh, my gosh.*

Sts *What word or phrase do you most overuse?*

Help with any other new vocabulary. Elicit or model the pronunciation of any difficult words.

- d** Put Sts in pairs to decide which question is the most and least interesting, or too personal to ask a person you don't know well. You might want to tell Sts that they don't have to agree with each other.

Get feedback from various pairs.

- e** Focus on the task and put Sts in pairs. Give them time to choose their six questions.

Now focus on the **Politely refusing to answer a question** box and go through it with the class. Elicit / Explain that these answers should be said very politely because usually, whoever asked you the question, didn't mean to be rude or intrusive.

Get Sts to ask and answer their questions. Encourage "questioners" to ask for more information where possible.

Get feedback by asking Sts for any interesting / funny answers, and help with any vocabulary problems that came up.

EXTRA SUPPORT Demonstrate the activity by getting Sts to choose questions to ask you. Give reasonably full answers and encourage Sts to ask follow-up questions.

2 GRAMMAR question formation

- a** **1.2** Focus on the instructions and make sure Sts understand the situation.

Play the audio once the whole way through for Sts just to listen.

Now play the audio again for Sts to write the four questions. If necessary, give Sts the first word of each question: *What, How, Don't, Can*.

Get Sts to compare with a partner, and then play the audio again if necessary.

Check answers.

- 1 What brings you to Toronto?
- 2 How long are you going to be in Toronto for?
- 3 Don't you like Toronto?
- 4 Can you tell us if there's any truth in that?

1.2

(script in the Student Book on p.122)

J = journalist, C = Cindy

All four journalists Excuse me..., Cindy..., Excuse me..., Cindy..., Excuse me....

J1 Just a few questions...

C OK, OK, but you have just one minute.

J1 What brings you to Toronto?

C I'm here to accept an award and do some interviews.

J2 How long are you going to be in Toronto for?

C Just 48 hours, then I'm flying back to the States.

J3 That's a very short stay. Don't you like Toronto?

C I love Toronto, but unfortunately my new movie starts shooting on Monday.

J4 There've been rumors that you and your husband are having relationship problems. Can you tell us if there's any truth in that?

C No, no, no, no. No comment. No, no more questions.

- b** Focus on the task and go through the questions. Make sure Sts remember what, for example, an auxiliary verb is (*do, have*, etc.).

Do it as a whole-class activity, or put Sts in pairs and then check answers.

a question that ends with a preposition = 2

a subject question, where there is no auxiliary verb = 1

a question that uses a negative auxiliary verb = 3

an indirect question = 4

- c** Tell Sts to go to **Grammar Bank 1A** on p.132. If your Sts have not used the *American English File* series before, explain that all the grammar rules and exercises are in this part of the book.

Grammar notes

The **Grammar notes** in this Teacher's Guide aim to add more information to the notes and rules on the **Grammar Bank** pages in the Student Book. There is a direct link between the number of each rule in the Teacher's Guide and the Student Book. If there is no extra information about a rule in the Teacher's Guide, this is either because we assume that Sts at this level should already know it, or because all the information needed is on the Student Book page.

Question formation

• Rule 1: basic word order in questions

Sts at this level should be familiar with basic rules regarding question formation, though they may still be making mistakes, especially when they speak.

• Rule 2: word order in negative questions

The word order is the same as in regular questions, i.e., just add *n't* to the auxiliary verb, e.g., *Aren't you going to come? Why didn't you tell me?*

You may want to point out that when full forms are used, you have to put the *not* between the subject and verb, e.g., *Are you not going to come? Why did you not tell me?*

You should point out to Sts that it is much more common to use the contracted negative, especially in spoken English.

Indirect questions

You may want to highlight that in this kind of question, the question is formed in the first part (*Can you tell me...?* etc.) and the main question becomes a regular clause.

Other expressions followed by the word order of indirect questions

Highlight that we only use a question mark when the introductory phrase is a question, e.g., *Could you tell me...?* *Do you have any idea...?* Where the introductory phrase is not a question, e.g., *I'm not sure...*, *I wonder...*, then the sentence ends with a period.

Focus on the example sentences for **question formation** and play audio 1.3 for Sts to listen and repeat. Encourage them to copy the rhythm. Then go through the rules with the class.

Repeat for **indirect questions** 1.4.

Then go through the **Other expressions followed by the word order of indirect questions** box with the class.

Now focus on the exercises and get Sts to do them individually or in pairs.

If they do them individually, get them to compare with a partner. Check answers, getting Sts to read the full questions.

- a**
- 1 Should I tell her how I feel?
 - 2 How long have you known your best friend?
 - 3 Could you tell me when the next train leaves?
 - 4 What are you thinking about?
 - 5 What do you like doing on the weekend?
 - 6 What kind of music does Junko like listening to?
 - 7 Do you know what time the movie finishes?
 - 8 How many students came to class yesterday?
 - 9 Do you remember where the restaurant is?
 - 10 Who does the housework in your family?
- b**
- 1 How often **do you usually exercise**?
 - 2 Who **wrote** *The Great Gatsby*?
 - 3 Could you tell me how much **this book costs**?
 - 4 I can't remember where **I parked** my car this morning.
 - 5 **Did you enjoy** your trip to Paris last weekend?
 - 6 What kind of work **does your sister do**?
 - 7 Who **ate / has eaten** the last cookie?
 - 8 Do you know what time **the swimming pool opens** on Saturdays?
 - 9 Why **didn't / doesn't your sister like** the present you gave her?
 - 10 **Do you have to** play your music so loud?

Tell Sts to go back to the main lesson **1A**.

EXTRA SUPPORT If you think Sts need more practice, you may want to give them the **Grammar** photocopiable activity at this point.

d Put Sts in pairs, **A** and **B**, preferably face-to-face. Tell them to go to **Communication Indirect questions, A** on p.106, **B** on p.110.

Go through the instructions and make sure Sts know what they have to do.

Monitor and help where necessary.

Check answers by getting some Sts to ask their questions.

Finally, help with any new vocabulary, and elicit or model the pronunciation.

Tell Sts to go back to the main lesson **1A**.

3 PRONUNCIATION intonation: showing interest

Pronunciation notes

Non-native speakers can unintentionally sound uninterested or even unfriendly if they use very flat intonation. The first two exercises focus on encouraging Sts to use a wide voice range when asking questions, and on stressing words.

These exercises do not focus specifically on distinguishing between the different intonation patterns for *yes / no* questions and question-word questions (*yes / no* questions usually have a rising intonation and question-word questions a falling intonation). In practice, we think it is very hard for Sts to notice this distinction, and, in addition, native speaker intonation is constantly changing, especially among young people.

In exercises **c**, **d**, and **e**, Sts focus on using interested intonation to respond to what someone says. This is another context in which using flat intonation (e.g., when responding *Really?*) can unintentionally convey a lack of interest.

a 1.5 Focus on the task. Tell Sts they are going to hear someone asking each question twice – once with interested intonation and once not – and they must decide which one has the more interested intonation. Play the audio once the whole way through for Sts just to listen.

Now play the audio again, pausing if necessary after each question has been asked twice.

Check answers. Elicit what difference Sts notice between the interested and uninterested intonation.

1 a 2 b 3 b 4 a 5 b

1.5

See questions in the Student Book on p.7

b 1.6 Tell Sts they will hear the five questions again with interested intonation. They must listen and then repeat the question, copying the intonation.

Play the audio, pausing after each question for Sts to listen and repeat.

1.6

See questions in a in the Student Book on p.7

Now repeat the activity, getting individual Sts to repeat each question.

c 1.7 Focus on the **Reacting to what someone says** box and go through it with the class.

Tell Sts they are going to hear five conversations, each starting with the questions in **a** in the same order, and they must fill in the blanks in the four reactions. Point out that the first one (*Wow*) has been done for them, and make sure Sts remember what a *vegan* is.

Play the audio once the whole way through for Sts just to listen.

Then play the audio again, pausing after each conversation for Sts to complete the expressions and questions.

Get Sts to compare with a partner, and then play the audio again as necessary.

Check answers.

2 Why not 3 Me too 4 How interesting 5 Oh, really

1.7

W = woman, M = man

1

W Do you have a big family?

M Yes, actually, I'm one of seven. I have five sisters and a brother.

W Wow! That's a huge family.

2

M What don't you like about the place where you live?

W Well, for one thing, I don't like my neighbors very much.

M Why not? What's wrong with them?

3

W What sports or games are you good at?

M Well, I'm not really very athletic, but I'm quite good at chess.

W Me too! We could play a game one day.

4

W Do you think you have a healthy diet?

M Yes, very. In fact I'm a vegan, so I only eat fruit and vegetables, and grains, and no meat or fish.

W How interesting! How long have you been a vegan?

5

M What makes you feel happy?

W Lots of things. Uh...like buying new shoes.

M Oh really? I can't think of anything worse!

d 1.8 Tell Sts that this time they are just going to hear the responses and they must repeat them. Highlight that with these responses, it is also very important to use interested intonation. Encourage them to use a wide voice range and to get the correct rhythm.

Play the audio, pausing after each response for Sts to listen and repeat.

1.8

1 Wow! That's a huge family.

2 Why not? What's wrong with them?

3 Me too! We could play a game one day.

4 How interesting! How long have you been a vegan?

5 Oh really? I can't think of anything worse!

Now repeat the activity, eliciting responses from individual Sts.

e Put Sts in pairs and get them to ask and answer the questions in a. Encourage them to use interested intonation and to react to their partner's answers. You could get some pairs to practice in front of the class.

4 READING & VOCABULARY

figuring out meaning from context

a Focus on the cartoon and do the questions as a whole-class activity, or put Sts in pairs and then get some feedback.

b Focus on the task and give Sts time to read the title and first paragraph.

Now focus on questions A–G and make sure Sts understand all the vocabulary, especially a *résumé* (= a written record of your education and the jobs you have done).

Put Sts in pairs and get them to answer the questions.

Get some feedback and elicit which question Sts would least like to answer. You could tell Sts which question you would least like to be asked.

EXTRA SUPPORT Read aloud the title and first paragraph, and do the task as a whole class, asking the questions to individual Sts.

c Focus on the article and give Sts time to read it and complete it with questions A–G, and find out how the questions should be answered.

Get Sts to compare with a partner, and then check answers.

EXTRA IDEA You may want to tell Sts what kind of companies the ones mentioned in the article are:

The Phoenix Partnership, Palantir Technologies, and Clearwater Analytics are software companies.

Condé Nast is a mass media company that publishes magazines.

Page Group and Switch Consulting are recruitment companies.

Badoo is a dating-focused social network.

EXTRA SUPPORT Before Sts read the article the first time, check whether you need to pre-teach any vocabulary, but not the highlighted words and phrases.

1 G 2 C 3 E 4 B 5 D 6 A 7 F

Finally, ask Sts if they would now feel more confident answering the questions.

d Focus on the **Guessing the meaning of new words and phrases** box and go through it with the class. Many of the texts in *American English File* Level 4 have glossaries, but obviously there will sometimes be other words whose meaning Sts can't guess and will want to check with a dictionary. Nowadays, many Sts will use online dictionaries via their phones. While these can be very useful, it's worth pointing out to Sts that there are circumstances, e.g., in exams, when they need to try to guess the meaning of words, and that if they always rely on their phones, they won't develop this skill. It is also sometimes not easy to find phrases or idioms in dictionaries, which is another reason for developing the skill of guessing from context.

Now tell Sts to read the article again, trying to guess what the highlighted words and phrases mean.

In pairs, Sts compare guesses.

e Now get Sts to match the highlighted words and phrases to definitions 1–8.

Check answers. Elicit or model pronunciation.

1 gut feeling 2 foolproof 3 light-hearted response 4 geek
5 work-life balance 6 the point of 7 good-natured rivalry
8 job-seekers

Find out how many of the words Sts guessed correctly and help with any other vocabulary problems.

f Focus on the task and make sure Sts understand *genuine* /'dʒenjuɪn/ (= real). Elicit or model its pronunciation.

Quickly go through the questions, making sure Sts understand all the vocabulary. If Sts ask about the companies mentioned in parentheses, you could tell them that Airbnb allows people to rent accommodations, Banana Republic and Next are clothing companies, Redbox software is a computing company, TES Global helps teachers and schools worldwide, and General Electrics is a multinational company dealing in transportation, renewable energy, healthcare, etc.

Put Sts in pairs or small groups to discuss what the questions tell the interviewers about the candidate, and whether this type of question really helps to choose the best candidate.

Get some feedback from various pairs or groups. You could tell Sts what you think or if you have been asked any similar questions at interviews.

- g** Put Sts in pairs and have them choose two questions in **f** to ask their partner.

Get some feedback for each question if possible, or ask Sts for the most interesting answers they heard.

5 LISTENING understanding the stages of a short interview

- a** Focus on the questions and elicit answers from the class. If you have a class of older adults, all of whom are likely to have had some kind of job interview, you could put Sts in pairs and then get some class feedback. Find out if any Sts have been asked tough interview questions as in the article in **4**.

- b** **1.9** Focus on the task and the chart. Give Sts time to look at the four fill-in-the-blank questions, and elicit / teach the meaning of *reincarnated* in **4**.

Play Speaker 1 all the way through and then pause the audio. Get Sts to complete the question.

Check the answer.

Now repeat the process for the other three speakers.

EXTRA SUPPORT Read through the script and decide if you need to pre-teach any new vocabulary before Sts listen.

- 1 have dinner, three people
- 2 have, boyfriend, get pregnant
- 3 practice philosophy
- 4 What animal

1.9

(script in the Student Book on p.122)

I = interviewer, **D** = Dominic, **H** = Heidi, **S** = Sean, **A** = Alice

1 Dominic

- I** Have you ever been asked a strange question in an interview?
D Yes, it was my first interview when I was applying to Sarah Lawrence University in New York – where I’m studying now.
I What was the question?
D The question was, “If you could have dinner with three people from the past, who would you choose and why?”
I And what did you answer?
I It was one of the first questions I was asked, and I said, “I can’t answer this right now. Can I answer at the end?” because I couldn’t think of anyone. So they said “OK,” and then they asked me the question again later, and I said something ridiculous like John Lennon, um, Picasso, and...uh...I can’t even remember who the third person was, it was another sort of artist or musician I think.
I Do you think it was a good question?
D Yes, because it made me think – I mean, it wasn’t something I was expecting at all, and all the other ones were more yes / no, direct questions, so this one made me think a little more.
I And you got in?
D Yes, I did.

2 Heidi

- I** Have you ever been asked a strange question in an interview?
H Yes, I have. That was many years ago, it was one of my first job interviews, in London, actually, after I moved to London from Germany. It was for a financial department, and the manager who interviewed me, I can’t remember, but I believe he, he must have been German – he asked me, “Do you have a boyfriend?” and “Are you planning to get pregnant?”

- I** That’s illegal now, isn’t it?
H Yes, I know, I believe that was illegal then.
I And what did you answer?
H I said no, I didn’t have a boyfriend, and I had no plans to get pregnant any time soon, but at that point, it was pretty clear to me that I did not want to work for that company.

3 Sean

- I** Have you ever been asked a strange question in an interview?
S Yes. I was being interviewed for a job with an advertising agency and the interviewer kept checking information on my résumé and then asking me about it, and he saw that I’d studied philosophy in college, and he said, “Oh, I see that you studied philosophy in college. Do you still practice philosophy?”
I What did you answer?
S I said the first thing that came into my head – I said, “Well, I still think a lot.”
I Was the interviewer impressed?
S Well, he obviously liked the answer, because I got the job.

4 Alice

- I** Have you ever been asked a strange question in an interview?
A There’s one I can think of, which was when I was being interviewed for a job with a company in Canada.
I What was it?
A Well, the interviewer asked me, “What animal would you like to be reincarnated as?”
I Weird question!
A Totally.
I What did you say?
A So I said a cat because it was the first thing I thought of and because cats have a good life – well, at least in the US they do. And then the interviewer immediately looked embarrassed and said that he’d been told to ask me that question to see how I’d react, but that he thought it was a stupid question.
I What happened in the end?
A I didn’t get the job, so maybe the interviewer wasn’t very fond of cats!

- c** Now tell Sts they will hear the audio again and this time they must take notes on how the people answered the questions and what happened in the end. Give Sts time to see if they can remember any of the answers.

Play the audio, pausing after each speaker to give Sts time to take notes. Play again if necessary.

Get Sts to compare with a partner, and then check answers.

EXTRA SUPPORT Check the answers to the first question (*How did they answer?*), then play the audio again and check the answers to the final question.

	How did they answer?	What happened in the end?
1	I can’t answer this right now. Can I answer this at the end? John Lennon, Picasso, and another artist or musician (he can’t remember).	He was accepted into the college.
2	No, I don’t have a boyfriend, and I have no plans to get pregnant.	She decided immediately that she didn’t want to work for that company.
3	Well, I still think a lot.	He got the job.
4	A cat	She didn’t get the job.

EXTRA SUPPORT If there's time, you could get Sts to listen again with the script on p.122, so they can see exactly what they understood / didn't understand. Translate / Explain any new words or phrases.

d Do this as a whole-class activity and elicit opinions.

6 SPEAKING

a Put Sts in pairs, **A** and **B**, preferably face-to-face. Tell them to go to **Communication Tough questions, A** on p.106, **B** on p.110.

Go through the instructions and make sure Sts know what they have to do. Make sure too that Sts understand the questions they're going to ask. You may need to explain, for example, *aspect* and *desert island* in **A**'s questions and *treat*, *superhero*, and *lead role* in **B**'s questions.

Get Sts to decide what kind of company they are interviewing for and then tell each other.

Tell Sts **A** to start by asking their partner the eight interview questions.

Monitor and help Sts, correcting any errors with question formation.

When they have finished, Sts **A** should tell their partner if they have got the job and why, or why not if they didn't succeed.

Then they switch roles.

Get feedback to find out if there were any particularly interesting answers. With a show of hands, you could also find out how many Sts got the jobs.

Finally, help with any new vocabulary, and elicit or model the pronunciation.

Tell Sts to go back to the main lesson **1A**.

b Focus on the task and give Sts time to write their question. You might want to remind Sts that the aim of the question is for potential future employers to get information about the candidate's personality and / or abilities.

EXTRA SUPPORT You could tell Sts to look back at all the previous questions in the lesson to help them with ideas, or elicit a few possible questions from the class so that Sts know what they have to do. Then get Sts to write their question in pairs. For **c**, divide the class in half (with one student from each pair in each group) for the mingle.

Monitor and correct any mistakes in question formation.

EXTRA CHALLENGE Get Sts to write two or three questions.

c If possible, get Sts to stand up and move around the class, asking as many other Sts as possible their question.

Help with any general vocabulary problems that came up.

d Do this as a whole-class activity and elicit opinions.